

Victoria Police Spending in Context

A Comparative Analysis of Police Resources, Workload, and Spending in B.C. Municipalities and Canadian Capital Cities

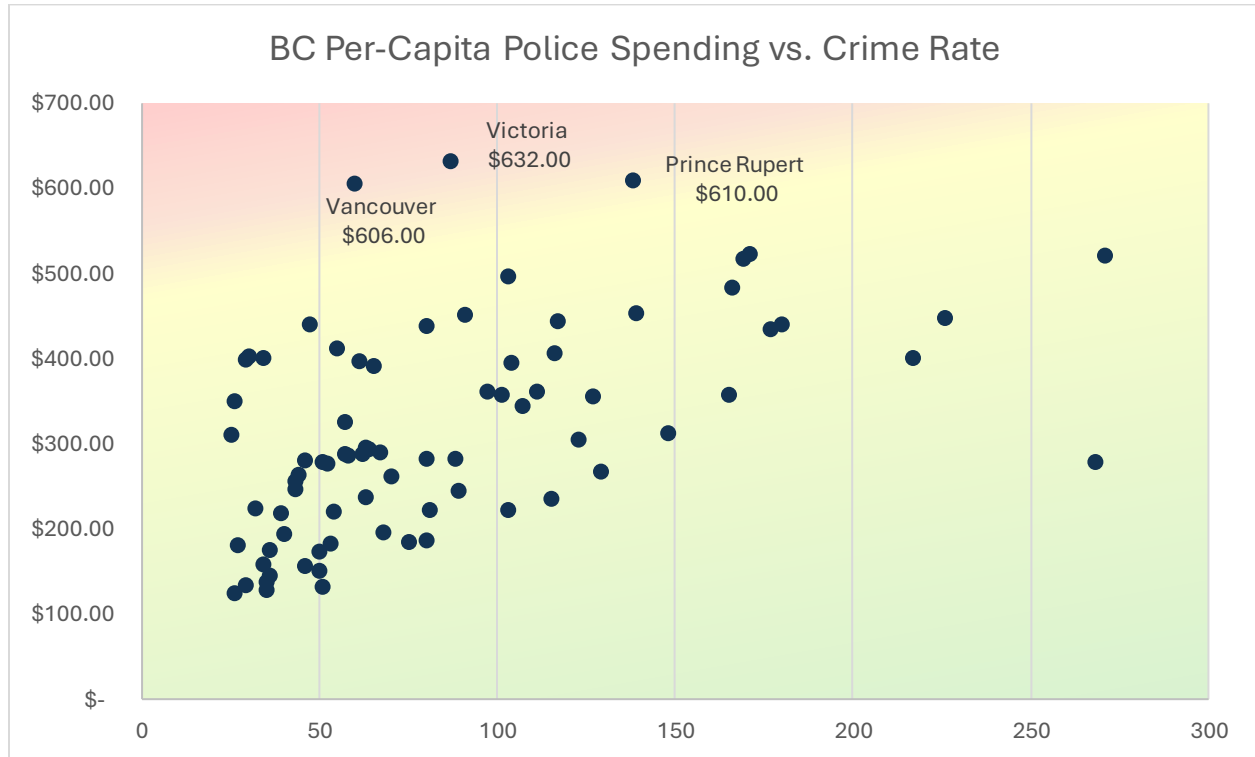


Figure 1: BC Per-Capita Police Spending vs. Crime Rate

Period & Methodology:

2024 B.C. municipal policing data and 2025–2026 Canadian capital-city budget data; comparative analysis of police staffing, expenditures, caseload, crime rates, and population.

Context

Police budget and operations are major citizen concerns, particularly during election years.

This analysis examines police spending in Victoria, British Columbia, in comparison with other municipalities in B.C. and other Canadian capital cities. The goal is to assess how Victoria's policing resources, spending, workload, and crime levels compare with comparable jurisdictions.

This analysis draws on two sources:

- BC Police Statistics: data on population, policing expenditures, caseload, crime rate, and officer counts for BC municipalities in 2024.
- Compiled Canadian Capital City Budgets: data on police and total operational budgets for 2025, and populations across Canada's capital cities.

Key Findings

Victoria stands out among B.C. municipalities for the number of police officers relative to its population.

- Victoria has the highest officer-to-population ratio among municipalities with populations over 15,000, at 21.04 officers per 10,000 residents. This is the highest officer-to-population ratio among all BC municipalities with their own municipal police forces.
- Victoria recorded the highest reported police spending per capita among the municipalities examined, at \$632 per resident, 101% higher than the average of \$314.77 (see *Fig. 2*)
- Victoria ranked only in the 22nd percentile for caseload, with approximately 41 crimes per officer.
- Victoria ranked in the 62nd percentile for crime rate, indicating that its crime rate was above the midpoint of the municipalities examined, but not among the very highest.
- Victoria was also among the top ten municipalities for spending per crime, at approximately \$7,249 per crime.

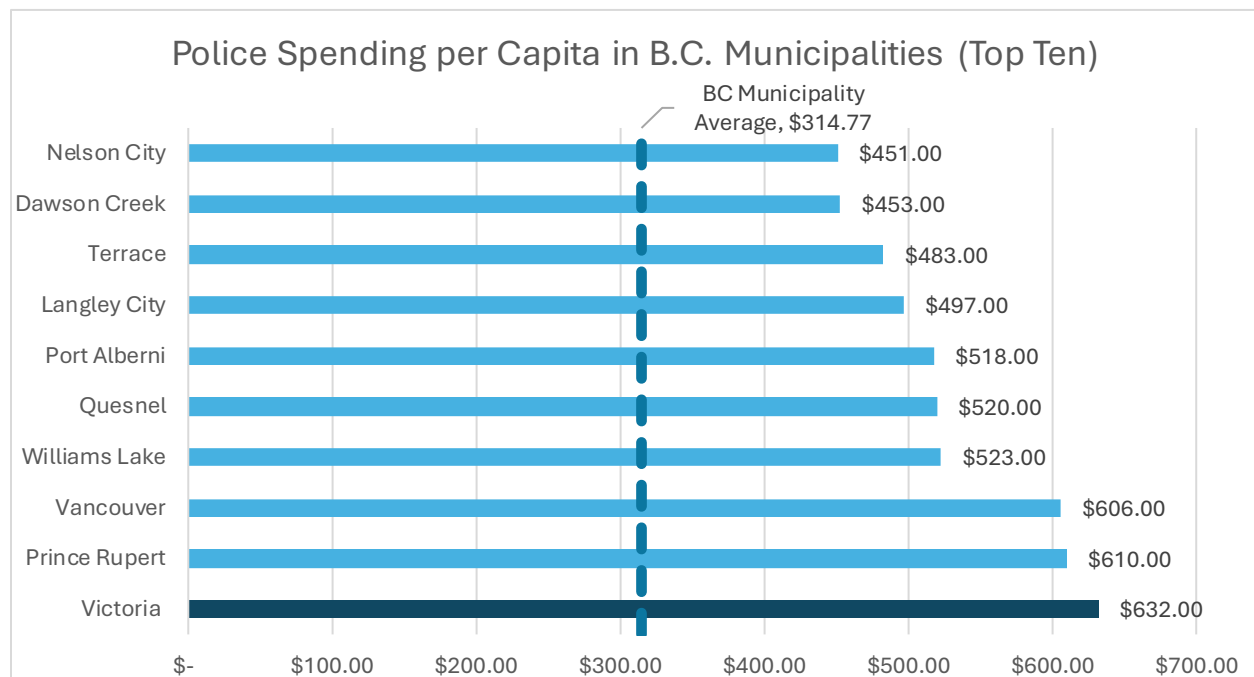


Figure 2: Police Spending per Capita in B.C. Municipalities

The comparison with other Canadian capital cities produces a similar picture of relatively high police spending in Victoria:

- Police spending represents approximately 23% of Victoria's total municipal budget, the second-highest share among Canadian capital cities, behind Winnipeg at 28%.
- Victoria has the highest police budget per capita among the Canadian capital cities examined, at approximately \$908 per resident (see *Fig. 3*).
- Victoria also experienced the largest year-over-year increase in police budget in 2026, increasing by 13.9%.

Taken together, the findings suggest that Victoria is an outlier in police resource allocation and spending relative to BC municipalities and Canadian capital cities.

The most notable pattern is the combination of high police staffing and spending with a comparatively low caseload per officer. Victoria's position in the 22nd percentile for caseload contrasts sharply with its leading position in police spending per capita and officer-to-population ratio.

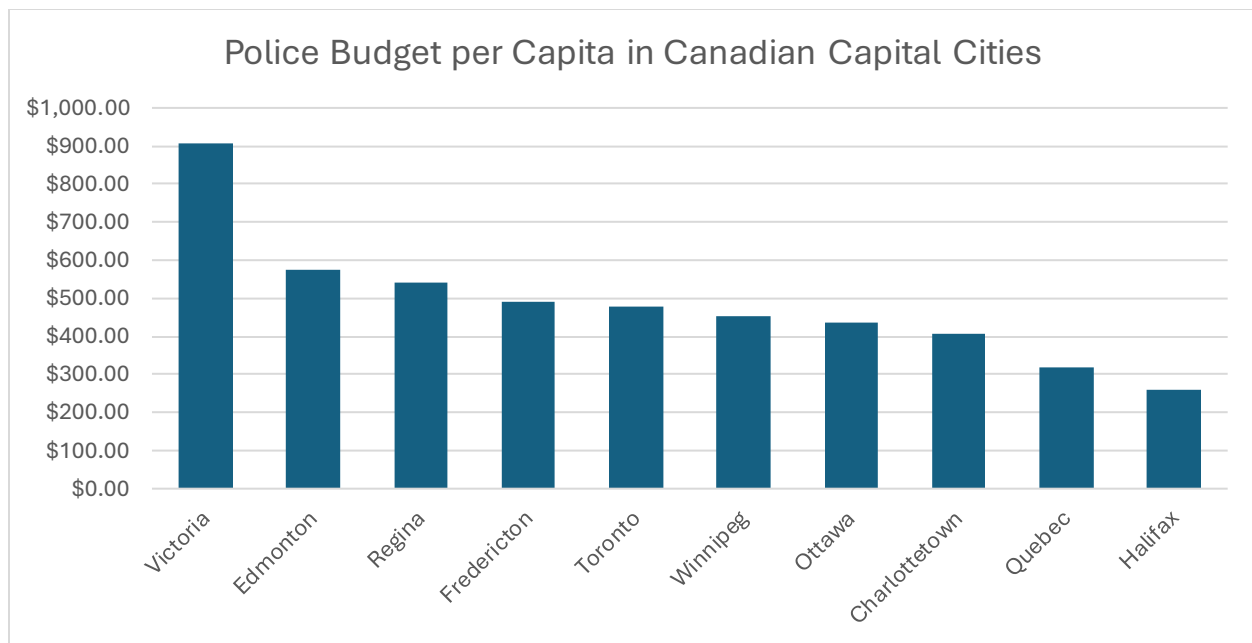


Figure 3: Police Budget per Capita in Canadian Capital Cities

The Canadian capital-city comparison reinforces this pattern. Victoria allocates a larger share of its municipal budget to policing than almost every other capital city and has the highest police budget per resident. The 13.9% increase in the 2026 police budget further indicates that this level of spending is continuing to grow.

Implications

The findings support three broad observations:

1. Victoria commits unusually high resources to policing: both officer staffing and spending per capita place Victoria at or near the top of the comparisons.
2. Police workload does not appear to be proportionally high: the city's relatively low caseload per officer suggests that its large police budget and workforce is not justified by number of reported crimes
3. Victoria's high spending warrants examination of efficiency and outcomes: the data establishes a significant difference in resource allocation, but it does not by itself establish whether that spending is justified, effective, or excessive. Additional analysis would be needed to evaluate outcomes, service demands, policing responsibilities, and differences in how municipalities account for police expenditures.

Limitations

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting these findings:

- Municipalities differ in size, geography, demographics, policing models, and service responsibilities.
- Crime rates and reported crime do not capture every dimension of police workload.
- Police budgets may include different categories of expenditures between jurisdictions.
- Population figures for Canadian capital cities are based on the most recent official census data, the 2021 Canadian Census, while police budget data are from 2025-2026; population-based measures may not fully reflect population changes since 2021.

Conclusions

Across both B.C. municipalities and Canadian capital cities, Victoria consistently appears as a high-spending jurisdiction for policing. It has the highest police spending per capita in both comparison frameworks, a very high officer-to-population ratio, one of the highest levels of spending relative to crime, and a police budget that accounts for a substantial share of the municipal budget.

At the same time, Victoria's comparatively low caseload per officer and mid-to-high crime-rate ranking suggest that the relationship between spending, staffing, workload, and crime is not straightforward.

The central question for further analysis is therefore not simply whether Victoria spends more on policing, but whether the additional resources produce proportionate public-safety and policing outcomes.

Appendix A: Data Availability and Sources

BC Municipal Police Data

The B.C. municipal police dataset was manually extracted from a single published report covering policing in B.C. municipalities. The report provides municipality-level information on population, police spending, police staffing, caseload, and crime. The extracted data was transcribed into a structured dataset for analysis. Derived measures, including spending per capita, officers per capita, crimes per officer, and spending per crime, were calculated from the reported figures.

1. British Columbia Ministry of Public Safety and Solicitor General, Policing and Security Branch. (2025). *Police resources in British Columbia, 2024*. <https://www2.gov.bc.ca/assets/gov/law-crime-and-justice/criminal-justice/police/publications/statistics/police-resources/police-resources-in-bc-2024.pdf>

Canadian Capital City Budget Data

The Canadian capital-city dataset was compiled specifically for this analysis from multiple publicly available sources. Population figures were obtained from Statistics Canada's Census data, while police operating budgets and total municipal budgets were obtained from individual municipal budget documents published by each capital city. The resulting dataset was standardized into a common format to enable cross-city comparison.

2. Statistics Canada. (2022). *Census Profile, 2021 Census of Population*. <https://www12.statcan.gc.ca/census-recensement/2021/dp-pd/prof/index.cfm>
3. City of Victoria. (2026). *Financial Plan 2026–2030*. <https://www.victoria.ca/media/file/2026-2030-financial-plan>
4. City of Edmonton. (2026). 2026 Approved Operating Budget. <https://www.edmonton.ca/sites/default/files/public-files/documents/2026-approved-operating-budget-april.pdf>
5. City of Regina. (2026). *Budget Book 2026*. <https://reginafiles.blob.core.windows.net/media/budgets/Budget%20Book%202026.pdf>
6. City of Winnipeg. (2026). *2026 Budget*. <https://www.winnipeg.ca/media/6207>
7. City of Toronto. (2026). *2026 City of Toronto Budget Summary*. <https://www.toronto.ca/wp-content/uploads/2026/05/8f04-2026-City-of-Toronto-Budget-Summary.pdf>
8. City of Ottawa. (2026). *Draft Budget 2026 Explorer*. <https://open.ottawa.ca/pages/budget-explorer#1>
9. Ville de Québec. (2026). *Budget 2026*. <https://www.ville.quebec.qc.ca/apropos/profil-financier/docs/budget2026-Detaille.pdf>
10. City of Fredericton. (2026). *2026 Annual Budget*. <https://pub-fredericton.escribemeetings.com/filestream.ashx?DocumentId=22556>
11. City of Charlottetown. (2026). *2025/26 Operating and Capital Budgets*. <https://www.charlottetownhall.ca/50037/widgets/211444/documents/158871>
12. City of Halifax. (2026). *2026/27 Municipal Budget*. https://cdn.halifax.ca/sites/default/files/documents/city-hall/budget-finances/2026-27-budget-and-business-plan_web_final_0.pdf

Appendix B: Analysis Materials

The source documents, manually extracted/compiled datasets, data-cleaning and analysis files, and supporting documentation are available in the project's GitHub repository. The repository is intended to support inspection of the data and calculations underlying the analysis and, where the source material and documentation permit, reproduction of the analytical results.

Project repository: <https://github.com/zakwht/vicpd>

The repository contains the following materials:

- **Source documents:** municipal budget documents and other publicly available source materials used in the analysis.
- **Cleaned data:** datasets prepared for analysis, including standardized variables, units, and municipality names.
- **Analysis:** spreadsheets and formulas used to calculate metrics and produce the analysis.
- **Documentation:** notes describing data sources, extraction methods, assumptions, data-cleaning decisions, and other methodological information.
- **Outputs:** tables and figures generated from the analysis.